Joint Attention and Common Knowledge: Assessing the Relational Approach

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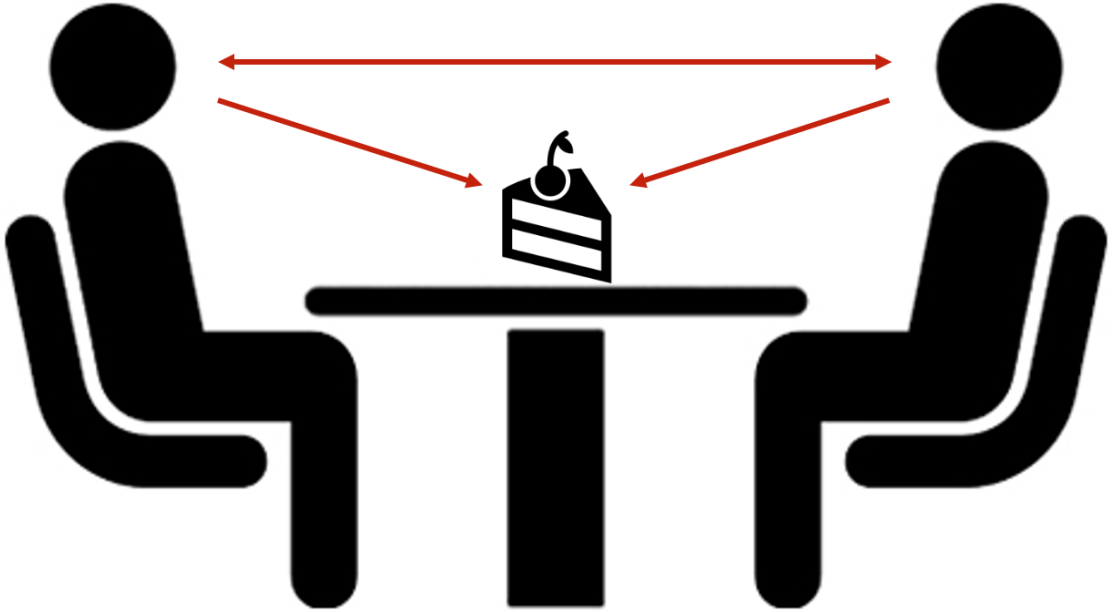
Outline

1. Setting the stage: what is joint attention?
2. Issue 1: Understanding co-attendance
3. Issue 2: Errors of joint attention
4. Future directions (?)

What is joint attention?



What is joint attention?

The phenomenon when:

- Two or more subjects attend together to an object, event or concept
- In a coordinated manner: both are monitoring each other's attention
- The situation is "open" or "mutually manifest" to both subjects. (Mutual awareness)

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Provides the categorical grounds that allow subjects to engage rationally in joint projects regarding the jointly attended object.

What is joint attention?

How to characterize the "jointness" in joint attention?

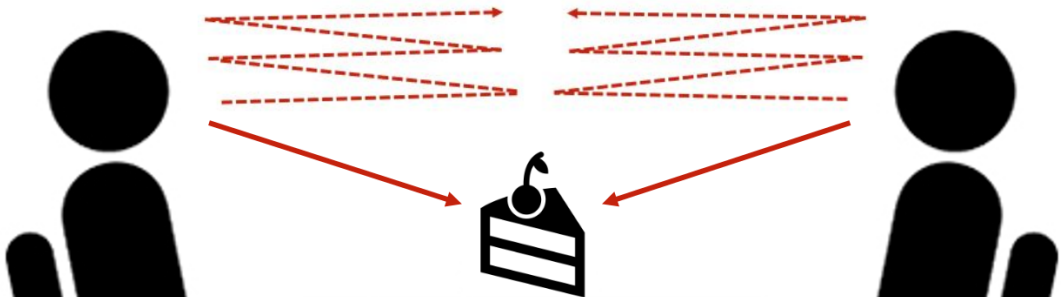
1. Knowledge-based view
2. Relational view

Knowledge-based view of joint attention

1. Iterative structure

If a group of individuals mutually know that p then

- all know that p
- all know that all know that p ...



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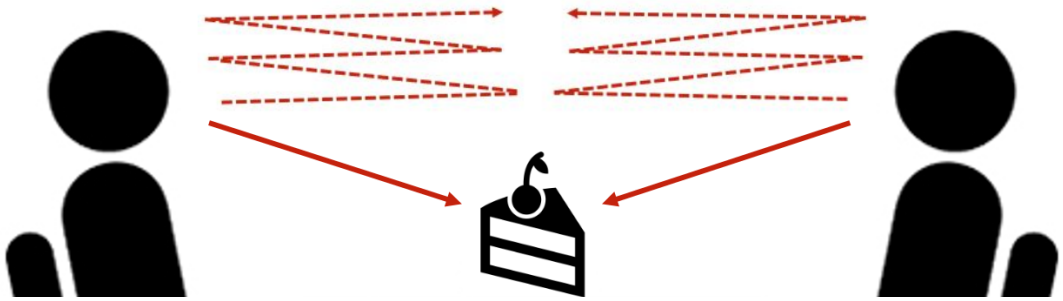

A and B are jointly attending to x iff

(1) A and B are each attending to x, and

(2) A and B each know that (are aware of) (1) and (2)

Knowledge-based view of joint attention

2. Understanding of a "normality" property

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I understand that:

- the other's gaze direction betrays her focus of attention
- whatever she is attending to, she is presumably aware of attending to it
- the other person also sees myself as someone "normal"

Knowledge-based vs. relational views

Campbell's worries

A finite mind cannot entertain an infinite iteration of psychological states!

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Relational solution:

1. NO iterative structure
2. NO requirement to understand a "normality" property

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Relational view of joint attention

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- Joint attention is a three-place primitive relation between two co-attenders and an object
- Joint attention is irreducible to the individual psychological states of each participant
- Joint attention is irreducible to further intermediary mental states such as representations
- It is a matter of perceptual experience, and does not involve making explicit inferences and reflective judgements, or engaging in deliberate reasoning

Why is this attractive?

Putative advantages

1. It is psychologically plausible.
2. It can deal with errors of joint attention, since the other person is a necessary constituent of a joint attentional experience in the first place.

Understanding of co-attendance

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What does it mean for the other to enter your experience as a co-attender?

Understanding of co-attendance

- To experience a tree as climbable $\longrightarrow$ I must have an understanding of what "being climbable" is.
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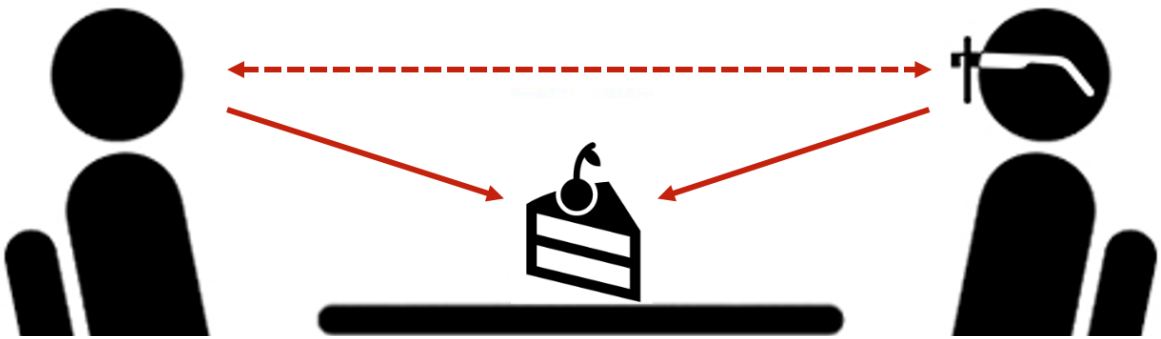
Understanding of co-attendance: background beliefs



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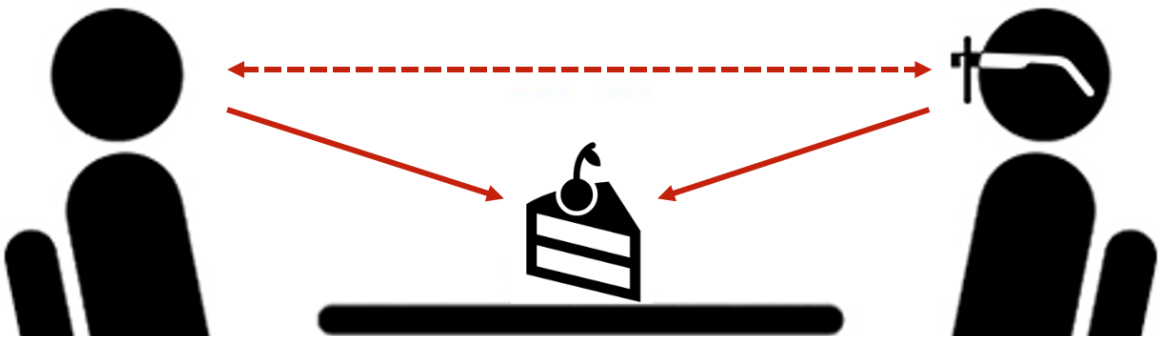

Joint attention is more than a purely perceptual phenomenon

Errors of joint attention

On a relational view, I did not have the kind of experience I took myself to be having. I took it that you were a constituent of my experience, as co-attender to the fish, when in fact you were not (Campbell, 2005, 289, my emph.).

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Worries

1. Perceptual experience is a personal level phenomenon, fully available to conscious awareness.
2. In the shift from genuine to erroneous joint attention, I am entirely unaware that a shift in my perceptual experience has occurred.

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Problematic asymmetry

1. Shift in perceptual experience
2. Shift in reflection

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Problematic asymmetry

1. Shift in perceptual experience
2. Shift in reflection
   Shift from non-reflection to reflection without myself noticing!

Conclusion

- There seems to be some sort of reflection or epistemic judgement going on.
- If we posit some sort of judgement, then genuine joint attention is not a merely primitive relational state.

Moving on...

Is Campbell right to dismiss representational approaches?

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3 possible interpretations

I They *must* perform the inferences.

II They must be entitled to perform the inferences, but mustn't necessarily do so.

III They don't need to be able to perfom the inferences. They only need to grasp conditions (1) - (2).

Thanks for your attention!

References

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